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- 1) Make a copy of this worksheet (File → make a copy)
- 2) Put your full name in the title
(ex: Copy of Pre-Call Assignment → Ali Alqaraghuli Pre-Call Assignment)
- 3) Answer the questions in as much detail as you can. This will only be seen by Ali and your accountability coach, Annie
- 4) Click “Share” and add **ali@nextlevelsystems.co** & **annie@nextlevelsystems.co**
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NEXT LEVEL
SYSTEMS

Questions:

1) What do I want? Business, Life, Relationships, How I look in the mirror, etc.

Had a light bulb moment a few weeks ago in thinking about the things I want to do and narrowing down my interests. I now think of the things I want to do in spheres based on my main and true and enduring interests, and for now, find it is the best way to articulate what I want to accomplish and be:

COMPREHENSIVE SPHERES OF ACTIVITY

1. Creative Industries Leadership

A. Cinematography (Bongani INC)

- Active DP/cinematography work for income and creative fulfillment. I do this now. www.bongaj.com
- Client relationships and industry networking
- Technical expertise development
- Selective project choices as other ventures grow

B. Film Production (DHAFU) - have had this idea for years now. Not started. Leveraging my 12-14 years of film industry experience and creativity.

- Creative Executive/Producer role
- Film Project development across USA/Zimbabwe/South Africa
- Story consultation and development
- Industry partnerships and cultural bridge-building

C. Film Community & Innovation Hub (Pollution Studios Transformation)

- Community-focused production facility based in LA.
- Hybrid model combining:
 - Commercial stage rentals
 - Coworking spaces
 - Educational programming
 - Equipment and technology access
- Membership tiers from Seed to Inner Circle
- Focus on DEI and accessibility
- Self-sustaining ecosystem supporting underrepresented creators

2. **Tennis Innovation & Lifestyle (Court Connoisseurs)**

A. Technology & Product Development

- Minimalist tennis shoe design
- VR tennis game with authentic physics
- Tournament/ladder management system
- Equipment innovations

B. Education & Community

- Tennis consulting/coaching
- Group organization
- Training methodologies
- Mental game development
- Zen tennis philosophy integration

C. Brand & Commerce

- Apparel line
- Equipment recommendations
- Affiliate partnerships
- Content creation
- Print-on-demand store

3. **Creative Expression & Performance** (more personal and life goals than business, for fun, for me, for enjoyment. Related to the other things in ways. Feed my soul)

A. Music & Sound

- DJ performances (3-4 times yearly)
- Music production
- Sound design
- Piano and musical background

B. Artistic Development

- Photography
- Light studies
- Visual arts integration
- Continued exploration of creative mediums

4. **Personal Development & Philosophy** (want to consistently incorporate these in my life and being. Things I do regularly or want to continue to do and incorporate)

A. Mind & Body

- Meditation & mindfulness
- Physical training
- Tennis as physical and mental development

B. Intellectual Growth

- Reading & writing
- Podcast consumption and creation
- Tutorial development
- Continuous learning
- Cross-disciplinary exploration

5. **Impact & Legacy** (long term goals and things I hope to achieve through doing all the other things).

A. Education Initiatives

- Workshops development
- Skills transfer
- Youth mentoring
- Film and tennis education programs

B. Cultural Bridge-Building

- USA-Zimbabwe-South Africa connections
- Arts & sports programs
- Cross-cultural exchange
- Community building through both film and tennis

Other thoughts:

I want to be able to buy the things I want (not that many or particular), but be free to just buy them. Financial independence!

I want a house with a tennis court which in LA needs me to earn about 300K/year. The most I have made in one year was 150K/yr then the film industry tanked and was on stand still and slow for the past two year. Also, that's about the most I can hope to make as a cinematographer unless I am a celebrity cinematographer, but producing/developing content and with my other ventures - the sky is the limit.

I don't want to be beholden to others' whims and their timelines. I want to create and inspire projects of my own, for myself, and for my friends - in film.

I want to move beyond planning and ideating and start executing more and building teams that help me continue executing and can sustain the businesses and endeavors.

I want plenty of free time for my creative pursuits.

To create meaningful, impactful stories through filmmaking that bridge cultures and perspectives, particularly connecting USA, Zimbabwe, and South Africa

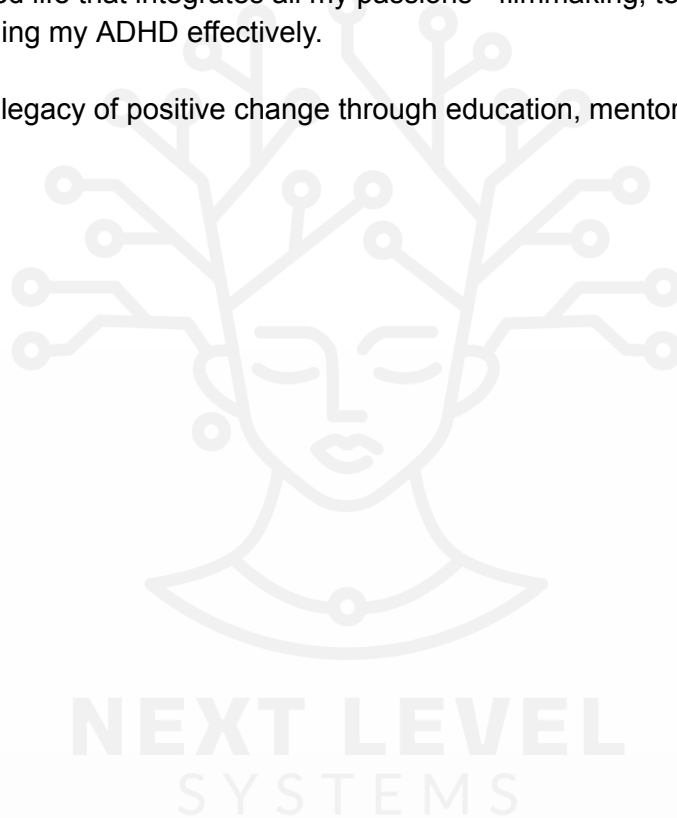
To build sustainable, community-focused spaces in both film and tennis (things I enjoy deeply and have given so much to me) that provide access and opportunities for underrepresented voices.

To find the sweet spot between commercial success and social impact where my ventures can be self-sustaining while staying true to their mission

To develop multiple streams of income that allow me to be selective about cinematography projects and invest more time in developing my film production company and tennis innovations and other pursuits.

To maintain a balanced life that integrates all my passions - filmmaking, tennis, music, personal growth - while managing my ADHD effectively.

Ultimately, to leave a legacy of positive change through education, mentorship, and creating pathways for others.



2) Where am I right now?

Mid-career cinematographer with growing recognition and opportunities, working on increasingly high-profile projects, but sometimes still doing passion projects for free with friends. I feel a bit stuck the last two years as the industry is super slow. So slow. And in the last year, my debt increased and income diminished. And there is uncertainty about this year. FYI, graduated school in 2010, started camera assisting, then became a full time cinematographer/DP in 2016. Moved to LA in 2018. Have shot about 4-6 feature films, many many short films, and many commercials and promos, some television, but haven't quite cracked that yet. I hope to do so this year if the industry opens up.

I still want to be a cinematographer, freelancing and enjoy this very much and will continue. It's the day job so to speak, but the film industry is unpredictable, so I can't guarantee my jobs or success. I would love to improve my chances though.

Developing multiple ventures simultaneously (film production company, tennis innovations, creative spaces) and feel like my ideas and plans are solid. I see the opportunities and ways things can be improved.

Building valuable industry relationships and partnerships. I am trying to make everything about developing relationships that can sustain all the projects, favors, and work that the businesses will take. I also just value community and authenticity as well.

Managing ADHD for the first time. Now 7 months in. It's been a wild ride so far. But I am hopeful I can full figure out systems and processes and with your help kick into high gear and get closer and closer to my dreams.

Growing understanding of business development and entrepreneurship. Trying to read more.

I am positioned uniquely with both technical expertise and creative vision in multiple fields. And see connections between things that others sometimes don't.

Starting to see my role as not just a creator but as a bridge-builder and community leader

In most things (the other businesses or expansions, etc) I am in the planning phase. On paper, it feels like I have seen the entire vision and structure and what is needed, but I struggle to break it down to manageable next steps or to execute.

I would like to also pursue my own film production company and the development and story ideas I have carried for years. They still call to me. I have the ideas and a slate of films and stories, but I lack the complete knowledge and know how, to go from idea to finished and distributed film. Or how to assemble the team to do so. I lack the connections and relationships too. I probably have more than I think, but just don't remember them. I understand parts of the process, but not everything. But I feel like I can see ways to make the path more efficient and accessible to independent filmmakers like myself. And I see great opportunities to be able to make films in the US and South Africa and join diaspora communities.

I also tangentially have access to a film stage/studio with gear, equipment, facilities for which I want to use to develop the film community hub that brings together filmmakers across experience levels and backgrounds who share the same collaboration, innovation, and creative aspirations and visions. It would end up becoming a self-sustaining ecosystem blending commercial production, coworking, and community-driven filmmaking support for underrepresented creators. It can function as both a base and free marketing for my film production company.

I play tennis regularly and am in communities that I enjoy and love, but see a lot of opportunity there as well. My heart is to help people and show a new way of being, to inspire people, to create community. I have connections to some vendors, some facilities, some coaches, and potential clients. And I have a plan for numerous tennis related products.

I struggle with getting up in the morning, but it has been improving trying some of the things that you have suggested and other stuff I've encountered across the internet. So for example, I used to take an hour or two to get out of bed in the morning. Now it's down to 30 minutes or an hour.

I feel like I'm quite avoidant or procrastinate around certain work tasks a lot, even for the things that I enjoy. I tend to like the idea part of thinking through it and figuring it out, but once I've figured it out, I don't have any motivation to kind of do more and it's almost like I know the tasks that are boring to me and kind of basic and so cannot build up the motivation to do them until it's really close to the deadline. Way too much procrastination.

It's also easy for me to just pick up a random task (especially for someone else), then just do it and get it done than to manage my own tasks. I think I have challenges prioritizing my day and tasks. Have tried several things to help and so far time blocking on my calendar has helped a little bit. But I may need to just try to stick to it more.

A lot of people would describe me as chill, a lot of people would describe me as being clever, a lot of people would describe me as being caring. The rest would say I am quiet or aloof.

3) How did I end up here?

- Started in Zimbabwe with limited film industry exposure but strong curiosity and creativity
- Moved to the US for education, driven by passion for visual effects that evolved into cinematography
- Worked my way up through camera department roles while developing technical and creative skills
- Built relationships and reputation through consistent quality work and positive set presence
- Discovered tennis as both personal passion and potential business opportunity. Also played in high school.
- Developed broader vision for community impact through experiences with industry inequities
- In retrospect, ADHD led to diverse interests and ability to see unique connections and opportunities
- Background spanning multiple cultures provided unique perspective and drive to create access for others

I was born in Zimbabwe and grew up in a family of six as the last born, alongside my twin sister. Growing up in Zimbabwe during the 90s was amazing. We were supposed to be the generation that could do anything - it was meant to be post-racial following independence in 1980. While it wasn't truly post-racial, we were free to dream. As the youngest kids with two older sisters, we had the most freedom to explore and were among the first in our extended family to pursue creative fields.

Schooling in Zimbabwe was strict and instilled discipline, but I'd always get an "F" for effort while still getting As by studying the night before and crushing it. This has been a pattern throughout my life. Looking back, this was clearly ADHD, though I was only diagnosed seven months ago at age 38. This experience taught me I could get a lot done in a short amount of time at the last minute. Rather than working in chunks, I tend to accomplish things in one big effort. Only with repeated professional tasks, like cinematography, have I learned to adjust my timing - realizing I might need two days instead of one, or six hours instead of two. Even then, my six hours often accomplishes what others might take 15 to do. Maintaining motivation over extended periods remains challenging.

My parents were very laissez-faire, which had its benefits but, like many parents in developing countries, this approach also led to some emotional neglect. Through my late teens into my 20s, I've done extensive work understanding my emotions, reading extensively, and learning through relationships. I've always been a self-improvement junkie, and my relationships have been growth catalysts. Teachers and mentors have been instrumental in enlightening my thinking, and I consume a lot of nonfiction - I love learning.

All the classic ADHD patterns fit my experience. Since my diagnosis, I'm retrospectively viewing my life through this lens, whereas before, these patterns were just "who I was." The diagnosis has freed me from many negative self-beliefs. Through the unmasking process, I'm rediscovering myself and retooling everything.

In my film industry career, I progressed quickly, accomplishing things faster than usual, especially notable as a person of color. However, I've hit obstacles, largely due to difficulties with networking, follow-up, executive tasks, planning, and goal setting. I've been moving in the right direction but without intentional strategies to accelerate progress.

The industry slowdown from the 2022 writer and actor strikes, continuing through 2023, made 2024 my slowest year ever - even slower than when I first started as an assistant, despite now being a cinematographer heading my departments. This extended period of unstructured time intensified my ADHD challenges, leading to lack of motivation and depression. Although I'd suspected ADHD for years, these circumstances finally pushed me to get diagnosed.

The past seven months have been a journey of discovery. I now have more clarity, motivation, and desire to achieve my long-held dreams. I've always felt I wasn't using my full potential, and understanding my ADHD helps explain why. Now, I'm ready to achieve my goals while helping others along the way.

Shortlist of significant people and events:

Borrowdale Primary school. St George's College.

Best Friend's group

Growing up in Zimbabwe was pretty amazing and free.

Gymnastics as a kid.

Tennis.

Reading and Learning so much.

Teachers at all school levels have really shaped my path and encouraged me.

Relationships - Amu, Paola, Ariel, Brittany, Vicki, etc.

Norry Niven, director (and Blue October)

Chris Rupert - early on in my career

James Laxton - film independent, Peter Flinckenberg and Jim Plannette, gaffer. David Claessen,

Will Rexer, Johnny Simmons, etc - mentors

Racism in America.

Diversity initiatives and organizations.

Sporas, Black in LA Camera

ASC, SOC, Industry organizations

Film Independent

Community

Parents - their love and own transformation. Then seeing how can impact them and help them grow.

Extended family. Diaspora experience.

World Travel - as limited as it's been. Travel has expanded my mind and soul.

Growing in emotional intelligence has been such a boon.
Growing in Self Care.
Therapy. Wow!
ADHD diagnosis.

4) What's stopping me from getting what I want?

- Time management and execution challenges related to ADHD
- Need for better systems and team support to implement ideas effectively
- Capital requirements for various ventures
- Balancing immediate income needs (cinematography) with long-term venture development
- Complex logistics of managing multiple projects simultaneously
- Need to build and maintain momentum across various initiatives
- Industry barriers and established systems that resist change
- Challenge of maintaining focus while pursuing multiple passions

I think execution is a big piece. Motivation is a big piece as well. But all these things have improved since being diagnosed last July 2024. First was figuring out medication, etc, then rediscovering myself, then waves of clarity in trying to reconfigure my life. Which then is how I ended up here.

I have just enough motivation that I want to get stuff done now, still working on medication dose, systems, etc, but at least I am not just wallowing on the floor and in my bed anymore. The desire to and drive to move the needle on my dreams is present.

I think the path is unclear.

My understanding of what exactly is holding me back is unclear too.

Usually once I am aware or know, it is easy for me to take action and or change my behavior, so I am hoping coaching can guide me to further clarity and function.

Maybe I have some limiting self beliefs. Not sure what, but what if I have just made myself small or the sidekick in someone else's hero story. Partly because of the ADHD and lack of motivation, but maybe also then what I have learned over all the years, I have always taken the back seat, passenger seat, but not been the one to drive (especially when others are involved). The paradox is cinematography where I am the leader and watch out for other people, but this

has taught me that I do have influence and sway and that people watch and respect me. But when it comes to personal endeavors or ideas outside of that, besides the executive dysfunction, maybe I just don't see myself being that person, the hero, the successful business person, the DJ on tour, the head of the tennis organization, etc. I always see myself as the person supporting whoever is leading. Because Ideas is all I am good at, but that's not really true. Also sometimes, ideas are all you need. Maybe I have just seen myself as too small. Even so, I think I do believe in myself and my ability and especially my ability to learn anything or solve any problem given time. But the person who is the focus of attention, etc. I somehow shy away from that. I am the DP, not the director.

An aside that is at least relevant to some amount of progress and gave me insight today: I saw a Mazda MX-5 and thought to myself that I want the car. It was a new thought and feeling. I have always thought I like my Mazda 2016 hatchback and will drive it forever, but then I thought why not just try to have the thing that I might enjoy and want. This is new. So the complacency or being okay with what I currently have (maybe due to no motivation or desire) that is the thing to unlearn and remove. A thought about being deserving of whatever I want and nice things and having the means to give myself or others those things.

I must be bold. And I must believe more boldly, even more so now, and see where it might take me.

If I achieve all these things, then what?

I also overall feel like I don't spend or prioritize more of my time for myself. It's easy to help other people or drop things to do tasks that will help other people, but I sometimes wonder if I need to be more selfish with my time. Some of this is poor habits around scheduling and tasks I reckon (in the absence of a clear thing I should be doing, I will do something else).

I do also think that executive is so huge in this area and honestly, A.I. has been such a godsend in helping me brain dump ideas and things and organize them for me. And in helping me doing more because the thought of even just having a little bit of help or the task being more manageable helps me actually just get it done and not avoid it as much. In an ideal world I would have a 24/7 assistant who can just help me do stuff or remember to do it.

I imagine I have a lot of bad habits. Poor sleep hygiene. Poor morning and wake up routines. I need to claim more of my focus and effort for me.

FYI, I am revisiting my affirmations. I did affirmations for a really long time for a while and feel like they helped me and so I am curious which ones I would still feel I need as a way to reverse engineering what my own doubts are. And the answer is...

Let me analyze potential continuing challenges based on project knowledge and recent developments, particularly considering the ongoing ADHD diagnosis integration process.

Current Limiting Beliefs/Challenges/Fears:

- **Imposter syndrome** in high-level environments (I am an outsider/innovator and afraid what others will think? I am not usually the represented person in those spaces?)
- Anxiety about consistent performance with ADHD
- Balancing multiple professional identities
- **Fear of not living up to potential**
- **Perfectionism** despite ADHD awareness
- Concern about follow-through
- **Tension between vision and execution**
- Navigating relationship dynamics with new awareness
- Uncertainty about new strategies
- Balancing medication with natural tendencies
- Trust in decision-making process
- **Balancing structure with creative freedom**
- **Fear of losing creative advantages of ADHD** (especially in my cinematography)
- **Maintaining authentic voice across cultures**
- Managing multiple cultural expectations
- **Sustainable business building**
- Acceptance of new ADHD understanding
- Maintaining creative confidence
- Patience with process



QUESTIONS

Reach out to people

Reach out to tennis people - tell them about idea and if they want to be a part?

Reach out to film people - what do you think, what would interest you about it?

Do you think this should exist?

If it did exist would you like to be a part of it?

20 people, reach out. As many as you can.

5 people

10 people

Lack of clarity.

Notebook LLM for both groups.



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